

Going around in circles

Stimac, a member of Croatia's first golden generation that finished third in the FIFA World Cup 1998, has been in charge of the national team for nearly five years now.

His predecessor, Stephen Constantine, had taken the team from 173rd to 97th in the FIFA rankings, helped it register a win in an AFC Asian Cup match — 4 against Thailand in 2019 — and won the SAFF Championship and the Intercontinental Cup.

All in a spell — his second in India — shorter than the Croat's. Stimac, after the Asian Cup's no-show, however, has repeatedly shifted goalposts instead of taking responsibility for the embarrassment in Doha.

Injuries, a decrease in quality depth, and a lack of football infrastructure in India were pointed out as reasons for the team's poor performance. There were also instances when he openly criticised his players, throwing them under the bus. He also highlighted the shortage of proper centre-forwards and players of Indian origin not being allowed to play for the country.

"I'm not sure if there is any other country that is not allowing players of their origin to represent their country," he said. "It is a huge handicap because there are many good players of Indian

origin playing in Europe's top leagues."

On another occasion, he opined, "At the lower level, we're going to dominate games. But to have better efficiency at the AFC Asian Cup, we need complete players. We either have players who can pass the ball or cannot match the strength, or the opposite. Something is missing."

While his claims are true to an extent, what did Stimac expect while taking up the job of a side ranked outside the top 100 of the FIFA rankings? **India was ranked 101 when he took up the job on April 4, 2019.**

After nearly five years under him, India's rank has fallen another spot — while registering 99th for a month — to 102 in the last rankings and is expected to fall further after the AFC Asian Cup.

Malaysia, 130th in the world, made a group stage exit two days after India's last game. But when it played against South Korea, ranked 23rd, it pushed Jurgen Klinsmann's

side to the edge, leading the game 2-1 at a point in time before being held to a 3-3 draw.

Both Tajikistan, ranked four spots below India, and Thailand, ranked 11 spots below India, have qualified for the round of 16 of the Asian Cup 2023.

Irrespective of which opponent they play, Stimac's boys must remember that the scoreboard remains 0-0 at kick-off. But with the lack of ownership after failures, it will be tough for India to dream of bigger things in the future.

The Blue Tigers face Afghanistan in the second round of FIFA World Cup 2026 qualifiers in March.

With an expanded 48-team World Cup in 2026, making it to the third round will be an easier task than in previous editions, but Stimac has cautioned that he cannot promise anything beyond that.

"I don't have a magic sword. I'm a hardworking guy who is asking you to turn things around and be patient because good things in football do not happen overnight. In the next 12 months, I will take you to the third round of World Cup qualifiers. I promise that," he said.

"But after that, things need to speed up, with investments, foreign coaches in Indian football academies, and more serious competitions for age-group sides."



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